

5 Signs Your Body Is Compensating

And what a bodywork specialist looks for that most therapists miss.

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Your Body Is Talking. Here's What It's Saying.

Something doesn't feel right. Maybe it's a hip that aches after every run. A shoulder that's been "tight" for months. A low back that flares up without warning. You've stretched. You've rested. Maybe you've even gotten a massage. But the problem keeps coming back.

Here's why: **the place that hurts is rarely the place that's broken.**

Your body is a compensation machine. When one area can't do its job (old injury, repetitive movement, dehydration, postural habits, scar tissue), everything around it picks up the slack. That compensation works. For a while. Until the area doing the extra work starts sending its own distress signals.

Most treatments chase the pain. They press where it hurts. They stretch what's tight. And they miss the reason it got that way in the first place.

I've spent 13 years reading bodies. Finding the patterns that create the pain, not just responding to symptoms. I trained at Cortiva Institute in Chicago with a heavy focus on myofascial release. I studied under chiropractors in Oregon. I hold certifications in three different barefoot massage disciplines. And I've learned that the body always tells you what's going on. You just have to know how to listen.

This guide walks you through five of the most common compensation patterns I see in my practice. Some will sound familiar. That's the point. Once you recognize what your body is doing, you can stop guessing and start getting to the root of it.

"Most therapists treat where it hurts. I look for why."

1

One Side Always Feels Tighter Than the Other

The pattern that hides in plain sight.

You notice it during a stretch, on the massage table, or when a trainer points it out: your left side is noticeably tighter than your right. Or one hip sits higher. Or your neck only turns smoothly in one direction.

This isn't random. Asymmetry like this is one of the clearest signs your body is compensating. Somewhere in the chain, often far from where you feel the tightness, a restriction is forcing the opposite side to overwork. The tight side isn't the problem. It's the side doing overtime because the other side can't pull its weight.

I see this constantly in runners and cyclists. A foot that doesn't dorsiflex properly changes the entire gait pattern. The hip on the opposite side compensates. The low back on the tight side locks up. Six months later, you're in my studio saying "my back is killing me." And nobody's looked at your ankle.

This is where fascia comes in. Think of the thin, filmy layer on a raw chicken breast. That's fascia. It wraps every muscle, organ, and bone in your body. When it gets stuck (from repetitive motion, dehydration, injury), it doesn't just affect the spot where it's restricted. It pulls on everything connected to it. Tightness on one side is often a fascial restriction broadcasting through the entire chain.

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT:

Pay attention to which side always feels tighter. Then start wondering what's happening on the other side. A specialist who works with the full fascial system can trace the chain and find where the restriction actually lives.

2

You've Had the Same "Knot" for Years

It's not a knot. It's a signal.

You know the spot. Right between your shoulder blades, or at the base of your skull, or in that one place on your upper trap that you could point to in your sleep. Every massage therapist hits it. It feels better for a day or two. Then it's back.

That persistent tension point isn't a knot that needs more pressure. It's a signal. Your body is telling you that something upstream or downstream of that spot isn't working correctly, and this area has been recruited to compensate. Pressing on it over and over treats the symptom without asking the question: **why does this muscle refuse to let go?**

Often the answer lives in the fascia. A restriction in the fascial layer is pulling the muscle into a shortened, guarded position. The muscle can't release because the fascial layer holding it won't let it. Other times, it's a postural pattern: your head sits two inches forward of your shoulders for eight hours a day at a desk, and those upper trap and rhomboid muscles are working nonstop to keep your head from falling further forward.

The fix isn't more pressure on the sore spot. It's finding the fascial adhesion or the structural pattern that created the problem and addressing that. When the cause resolves, the symptom lets go on its own.

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT:

If you've had the same sore spot for more than a few months, stop asking for more pressure on it. Start asking why it's there. The answer is almost never in the spot itself.

3

Your Pain Moves Around

Fix one thing, another thing flares up.

You get your low back sorted out. Great. Now your hip is bothering you. The hip calms down and suddenly your knee is the problem. It feels like your body is playing whack-a-mole, and you're always one step behind.

Migrating pain is a hallmark of compensation. When a therapist releases one overworked area without addressing the underlying restriction, the load simply shifts to the next link in the chain. The relief is real. That area genuinely needed the work. But the root cause is still driving the pattern. So the body finds a new place to park the stress.

This is especially common with repetitive motion injuries and postural dysfunction. The structural imbalance creates a cascading series of compensations. If you only treat the loudest one, the next in line gets louder.

In my practice, when a client tells me "it moves around," that's actually good diagnostic information. It tells me we're dealing with a systemic pattern, not an isolated injury. It changes my whole approach. Instead of chasing the pain, I'm looking at the body as a connected system and asking which restriction is driving the chain.

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT:

Keep a simple note on your phone: where it hurts, when it started, and what came before it. That sequence is a map. A bodywork specialist who treats the whole chain, not just the current complaint, can use that map to find the origin point.

4

You Feel Stiff Even Though You Stretch

Flexibility and mobility aren't the same thing.

You stretch every day. You might even do yoga. You're not inflexible. But you wake up stiff. After sitting for an hour, you feel locked up. Your body never quite feels loose, no matter how many hamstring stretches you do.

Here's the distinction most people miss: **stretching lengthens muscle. It doesn't release fascia.** If your stiffness is fascial (and it usually is), stretching alone won't fix it. You can stretch a muscle all day, but if the fascial layer surrounding it is adhered or dehydrated, the muscle can't access its full range of motion. It's like trying to stretch while wearing a shirt that's two sizes too small.

Fascia responds to different input than muscle does. It needs sustained pressure, hydration, and specific techniques (myofascial release, cupping, gua sha, instrument-assisted work) that target the fascial layer directly. This is one of the reasons I use the tools I use. Ashiatsu (barefoot massage) delivers broad, deep, sustained pressure across large fascial planes in a way that hands simply can't replicate. It's one of the most effective tools for fascial work that exists.

Dehydration compounds the problem. Fascia that isn't adequately hydrated becomes sticky, rigid, and resistant to movement. This is why you feel stiffer in the winter, after illness, or when you've been under-hydrating. The tissue itself is less pliable.

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT:

If stretching isn't solving your stiffness, the issue probably isn't in the muscles. Hydrate deliberately. Your fascia needs water as much as your muscles do. And find a practitioner who works with the fascial system directly, not just the muscles on top of it.

5

You've Stopped Trusting Your Body

The compensation you can't see on a table.

This one doesn't show up on an anatomy chart. But it might be the most important sign of all.

You've started avoiding things. You don't sign up for the race because your knee "might" flare up. You skip the hike because your back was "a little off" yesterday. You've stopped reaching overhead with confidence. You brace before you bend. You plan your day around what your body might or might not let you do.

That's compensation of a different kind. It's your nervous system telling you that it doesn't trust the structural system to hold up under load. And it makes sense. If your body has been sending you pain signals for months or years, of course you start protecting yourself. But the protection becomes its own problem: you move less, the tissue gets stiffer, the compensation deepens, and the fear reinforces itself.

This is personal for me. I became a bodywork specialist because a holistic doctor restored my faith in my own body when conventional medicine couldn't. I was studying opera in college. I developed a hiatal hernia that no conventional doctor could explain. I went to doctor after doctor. Nothing worked. One visit with a holistic practitioner, and the problem was resolved. That experience changed the entire trajectory of my life.

I became what I call a "healing facilitator." My job isn't just to work on your tissue. It's to help you trust your body again. To help you understand what's happening, why it's happening, and what to do about it. When a client walks out knowing more about their body than when they walked in, that's the session that matters.

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT:

If you've been modifying your life around your body's limitations, that's a sign the root cause hasn't been addressed. You don't have to keep managing around the problem. Find a specialist who looks at the full picture. Not just where it hurts, but why.

What Comes Next

If you recognized yourself in one or more of these signs, you're not broken. Your body is doing exactly what it's designed to do: compensating to keep you moving. The problem isn't the compensation. The problem is that nobody has found the reason for it.

That's what I do. Every session in my practice starts with an assessment. I look at how your body moves, where it's restricted, and what patterns are driving the symptoms you're feeling. Then I choose the tools (Ashiatsu, myofascial release, cupping, gua sha, deep tissue) based on what your body needs that day. You don't pick from a menu. You trust a specialist.

I've been studying how the body works since I was three years old, starting with the holistic doctor I grew up seeing. I trained at Cortiva Institute in Chicago with a heavy focus on myofascial release. I worked with chiropractors in Oregon, including the dean of a chiropractic school. I hold certifications in three distinct barefoot massage disciplines. And I'm currently pursuing chiropractic education at NMC, because the body never stops teaching, and neither do I.

If you're ready to stop chasing the pain and start finding the cause, I'd welcome the chance to work with you.

Book a Session

You pick the time. I pick the tools.

60 min • 75 min • 90 min • 120 min

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“Your body is trying to tell you something. I listen. And I go further than most therapists are trained to go.”